

Spiritual Authority in the Kingdom of God

Greatness Means the Full Measure of Your Own Calling

Passing in review, let us begin again with Matthew 18:1:

At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus,
saying,
Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?

What an interesting statement. Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven? Who has the most authority? Who has the highest position? Who is greatest?

Again, I am not going to lie to you. I know what this verse is talking about, and we will get into it more, but I am not going to tell you I do not want to fulfill the maximum of what God has called me to fulfill on this earth.

I am called to what I am called to, and you are called to what you are called to.

What is greatness?

I am an evangelist. I evangelize. I teach. But I would be lying if I said I did not want the full capacity of my call. I would not be falsely humble. I want all of it. I am a spiritual hog.

You should feel the same way. I am not called to do what you do, but you are called to do what you do. Then you should be a hog. You should want to fill it all in all, full capacity. That is greatness in the kingdom.

I do not know what you have asked. My question is rather simple: a swath a mile wide and a yard deep around the earth two or three times, maybe a billion people, and can I take them home with me? Is that asking too much?

Would to God He gave me a bunch like you to get there with.

That caught my interest when I broke this verse down.

Jesus Places a Child in the Middle of the Search for Authority

To illustrate who is greatest in the kingdom of God, of all things, Jesus took a little child and placed him in their midst. Can you get over that?

To illustrate great authority and greatness in the kingdom of God, He put a child out there. I could not get over it. That does not fit the macho, "Let us kill a few Goliaths" image in our hearts.

He placed a child in their midst, and I want you to notice what He said:

And Jesus called a little child unto him,
and set him in the midst of them,
And said,
Verily I say unto you,
Except ye be converted,
and become as little children,
ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven.
Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child,
the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.
And whoso shall receive one such little child in my name
receiveth me.
But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me,
it were better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck,
and that he were drowned in the depth of the sea.

Do you not think I got my meditator out and meditated on "child"? I wanted to find out how to achieve spiritual greatness, not high, self-exalted, "Look at me and my position, and look at you and yours" greatness.

I want spirit. I want it, or I would rather be dead. I want to know what He is talking about more than anything I can think of.

He said, "Except you first become converted and become as this little child." Two steps: conversion, and becoming as this little child. Humble yourself as this little child.

The Childlike One Is Trusting, Forgiving, and Utterly Teachable

We found out the three main attributes of a child.

Number one, he is all trusting. He trusts mama and dad.

Number two, he is quick to forgive. A little child is so quick to forgive that the sun almost never sets on the wrath of a child. The parents may carry on the war for a year, and it all started because the children got into a slap fight. The children make up fifteen minutes later, but the parents carry it for a year.

The nature of a child is quick to forgive.

Thirdly, a child is one thousand percent teachable.

That is why Jesus makes the switch to the child being taught and the one teaching the child. He said, "Whoever receives this humble, teachable, all-trusting, forgiving one receives Me. Whoever offends this all-trusting, forgiving, teachable little one offends Me."

Jesus said, "I am offended."

Who does the greater responsibility fall on? The teachable one who has experienced conversion and humbled himself? He wants to know everything. That is why he is so vulnerable. Therefore, the greater responsibility lies on the one teaching the little one.

Jesus said:

Woe unto the world because of offences!
for it must needs be that offences come;
but woe to that man by whom the offence cometh!

If your hand offends you, cut it off. If your eye offends you, pluck it out. In the same passage, He means anything in you that is offensive and would cause a little one to fall, get rid of it.

That is the value He puts on an all-forgiving, trusting, teachable little one.

Who is going to serve them? Who is going to serve these little ones?

The Teachable Convert Can Be Hurt by Bad Teaching

Jesus said, "Except you become converted and as a little child."

When I was born again, I became a new creation. I was born again in my spirit. Then I remember getting filled with the Holy Ghost. I stammered all over it, but when I got home, I walked around the front room holding my hands up to Jesus, praising Him full of the Holy Spirit.

My hands got hot. When it reached my chest, I fell down under the power. It knocked the wind out of me, and it came out in tongues. He had to knock me out to get it over to me.

Think you had trouble receiving it?

When I came out of it, my mouth was numb. It felt like I was at the end of a tunnel. I prayed in tongues until it was almost time to go to work. It was glorious.

I received diversities of tongues. I received the call of God that night. After all that tongue-talking, when it finally lifted and I could get my breath, the Lord said to me, "You are called."

I said, "Whoa, wait a minute. I am the one who got D's in English, remember?"

"You are the kind I want. We can mold you."

So this totally teachable, humble, hungry, forgiving little one goes to church, and they get up and say, "God brought that disease on you to teach you something."

I said, "Give me another bottle."

"He took your money to teach you a lesson."

"Give me another bottle."

"God did it."

I ate anything they gave me.

Therefore, the greater responsibility is on he who receives the little one. Who is going to serve these people? Who is going to serve them from the table of God?

What is greatness in the kingdom? What is it? Who is it? What is authority? Who has it?

Zebedee's Sons Asked for Authority the Way the World Understands It

Go to Matthew 20:20:

Then came to him the mother of Zebedee's children with her sons,
worshipping him,
and desiring a certain thing of him.
And he said unto her,
What wilt thou?
She saith unto him,
Grant that these my two sons may sit,
the one on thy right hand,
and the other on the left,
in thy kingdom.

Let us stop here for a minute.

She and her sons, and Zebedee too, actually thought Jesus was going to lead some kind of revolt and overthrow the Roman Empire, something like Moses as a mighty conqueror and deliverer, and deliver the whole thing back to Jerusalem.

So she wanted to make sure her two sons had a high place of authority, one on His left hand and one on His right.

It took a while for my lightning-quick mind to catch on to this, but it finally did. He was talking about authority, a high-ranking position in the kingdom. That is what they wanted, and that is what Jesus addressed.

I knew if I could ever break these verses, then I could find out how real, honest-to-God authority comes to a man in the kingdom of God.

Jesus answered:

Ye know not what ye ask.

Are ye able to drink of the cup that I shall drink of,
and to be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with?

They say unto him,

We are able.

And he saith unto them,

Ye shall drink indeed of my cup,
and be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with:

but to sit on my right hand,

and on my left,

is not mine to give,

but it shall be given to them for whom it is prepared of my Father.

Have you ever stopped there and wondered who in the world would have that honor? If it is you, you are going to have to go a little to beat Paul out.

Throughout eternity, Paul will run around heaven by the revelation he recorded and documented, principles from the heart of God that survived rivers of blood, survived entire civilizations being wiped out, and have been handed to you and me with a price tag we have no idea of.

To think that it could sit on your shelf and collect dust hurts me all the way down to my toenails.

What an honor. I think one of those places might be Paul, and the other might be John. But Jesus would not tell them, so I would not dare say for sure.

Kingdom Authority Does Not Come by Dominion or Force

The request moved the ten to indignation:

And when the ten heard it,

they were moved with indignation against the two brethren.

But Jesus called them unto him,

and said,

Ye know that the princes of the Gentiles exercise dominion over them,

and they that are great exercise authority upon them.

In other words, the land was divided into provinces and cities, something like our counties. A prince was over a province, but the great ones, the kings, exercised authority over the princes who exercised dominion. They dominated the people.

After Jesus brought this truth to the ten, they never asked Him again about a high-ranking position of authority, because they knew how and where it came from.

The great ones, the kings, exercised authority over the princes who exercised dominion. I used to love those Roman movies. Caesar would wave a finger, and everybody would duck because he might point at somebody and have him executed.

They got to thinking they were gods. The worms changed their minds. It is embarrassing to be eaten right on the throne.

When Jesus called the ten over because they were moved with indignation, what He told them has rung in my spirit ever since:

But it shall not be so among you:
but whosoever will be great among you,
let him be your minister;
And whosoever will be chief among you,
let him be your servant.

What shall not be so? You will not dominate, nor will you have great authority by force. Great spiritual authority in the kingdom of God does not come that way.

I love it. It separates the men from the boys and the women from the girls.

Spiritual Authority Is Power Over What Hinders the Spirit's Work

If that is not the way authority comes, how does it come?

Spiritual authority is the power to exercise dominion over any and all opposing forces or circumstances that hinder the work of the Holy Spirit in your life.

The problem is not the mountain that refuses to move out of the way. The problem is that you do not have the faith to move it.

The problem is not your finances.

"Yes, it is. I am broke."

No. The problem is your inability to believe God for it.

The problem is not the disease in your body.

"Yes, it is, buddy. You are not the one wearing this. You are not the one with a heart that could give up any minute."

No. The problem is not in your body. He took care of all these things two thousand years ago, and He has already sent them out. It is not a matter of whether He is sitting up there saying, "I think I will heal this one and let this one go. I really like the way that lady is dressed. I think I will heal her."

It is not a matter of picking and choosing. It has already been prepackaged. It has been sent out. It is in the mail. It is on the way. All you have to do is receive it.

"That is harder than you think."

I know. That is why He sends teachers and preachers down the road to say, "Listen to me. He has to find servants who are willing to give their lives to God, willing to challenge the devil, willing to do what it takes to be taught by the Spirit."

Where do you think all the moves of God that shook nations came from? They started with one stubborn Christian who refused to turn.

Usually it is not your great men who cause the revival. It is you. Sometimes God sends men in, teachers and preachers, to help mature the move, but very few are caused by the men themselves.

Again, spiritual authority is the power to exercise dominion over any and all opposing forces or circumstances that hinder the work of the Holy Spirit in your life.

The Body's Offices Rest on the Foundation of Tongues

What is authority? Jesus said:

It shall not be so among you:
but whosoever will be great among you,
let him be your minister;
And whosoever will be chief among you,
let him be your servant.

Spiritual authority and greatness in the kingdom of God do not come like they do in the world. They come from serving.

Go to First Corinthians 12:27:

Now ye are the body of Christ,
and members in particular.

No argument there. I am an individual member in a massive body called the body of Christ, and the way I entered it was by rebirth. If you are born again, you are a member in particular in the body of Christ.

Then He categorizes you. He puts you in one of these callings. You fit in one of them. It is all listed right here:

And God hath set some in the church,
first apostles,
secondarily prophets,
thirdly teachers,
after that miracles,
then gifts of healings,
helps,
governments,
diversities of tongues.

There may be an apostle in here. Maybe two. You probably do not know it yet. There are enough preachers and preacher-trainees to get one out of here anyway.

Diversities of tongues means all the diverse operations of the gift of tongues: tongues with interpretation, tongues for personal edification, tongues as a sign to the unbeliever, and all the diversities of it. But notice that it is the foundation. It is the one everyone can have that undergirds the development of all the other offices. They rest on it.

Paul asks:

Are all apostles?
are all prophets?
are all teachers?
are all workers of miracles?
Have all the gifts of healing?
do all speak with tongues?
do all interpret?

He is speaking strictly in the sense of ministry. Not everybody prays in tongues and interprets over people. But everybody can speak with tongues for personal edification.

Have you received the Spirit since you believed? Yes. But not everybody ministers in tongues. Many times when I am praying for you, tongues will go off in me, and then suddenly the English interpretation will come, and I will know more accurately how to pray for you.

I minister in it, and in miracles, and in healings, and certainly evangelism, which is included in miracles and healings. I am finding my place.

Lord, I wish I were called to be one of those earth-shaking apostles who would cut a swath a yard deep, a mile wide, three times around the earth. I do not know yet. I hope it is in my destination. If it is not, I hope I can change God's mind. But if I cannot, I will take what I can get.

You fit in there somewhere.

Coveting the Best Gifts Requires the More Excellent Way of Love

Paul says:

But covet earnestly the best gifts:
and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.

God wants you to be that servant, fully equipped. In the office He has called you to, He wants you to covet the best gifts that go with that office.

Notice the verse closely: "Covet earnestly the best gifts, and yet I show you a more excellent way." A more excellent way to what? A more excellent way to covet the best gifts.

You know what covet means. The Ten Commandments say, "Thou shalt not covet." It is strong.

I have seen men with ministries, and I coveted them. I hurt. I slept in halls. I did not even leave my wife enough money to live on. She has been through it all. She knew I was consumed.

I drove rat-trap cars that fell apart almost every time on the way to the meeting, tied together with baling wire and running on junkyard tires. I rented a five-dollar hall and ran a twelve-dollar paper ad: "Plan to attend a miracle service." I figured out what to do with them after I got them there.

I counted it a privilege to walk out with three people and pour my heart out. He paid me to preach, not to wait for doors to open.

How dare you sit around and wait for a group of believers to invite you in when you have a call on you and half the people around you are going to hell? How dare you then go for counseling because your needs are not met?

I am not belittling anybody. I am telling you what drove me.

How do I know I am called? I cannot give up.

I believed God with everything in me. I would wait for the people to leave and sneak back in until the fire marshal caught me. I would roll my sleeping bag out under a table and sleep there. If I got caught, I would sleep in my car. I did not care. I got to go out and preach to people, and it was the only way I could quench what was eating me on the inside.

Then God started using me in miracles and filling people's teeth. God, it was awesome.

"Let me see. Let me see, please. I want to see it again."

There would be a big cross in it. "Let me see it again."

I had just come out of ultra-holiness, where they taught external holiness by works. I worked so hard for God, loved Him so much. Anything anybody told me to do, I tried to do. To think the holy God was close enough to occupy the same room with me and do a miracle was more than I could conceive.

I would hold my breath between services, thinking maybe I would do something that would cause Him not to show up again, until I found out about my righteousness by grace and how to run into the arms of my Father.

You want to talk about coveting? He said to covet the best gifts, but He also said, "I show you a more excellent way."

What more excellent way? The more excellent way to go after the gifts is by strengthening and establishing the foundation they work off of.

The Gifts Are for Serving People, Not Admiring Yourself

Oh, I loved God. I loved Him with all my heart. I had to learn to love people.

I had to face it: what did I want the power for? Oh yes, I wanted to be close to God. But why else? The admiration of men?

If you do not love people, what do you want it for?

You want the gifts to operate in you. You want to be a servant. You want to meet people's needs. You want authority. All that faith you are trying to change the world with, turn some of it on yourself. Change.

You want to covet the best gifts? Fall in love with the person next to you, because if you do, God will make sure you have what you need to serve him.

What do you want vast amounts of money for? Security?

This was one of my hardest battles. I will be honest with you. I had nothing. Then all of a sudden people thought I was something. Nobody wanted me until God started using me. If God uses you, so will men.

I had nothing, and then He started blessing my socks off. It was a battle. He wanted more and more. He wanted airplanes, print shops, television shops. I wanted to stay ahead of who was who in Oregon. That is not a servant's heart.

Covet earnestly the best gifts. Go after them, all right. But He shows you a more excellent way to receive them.

What do you want your vast amounts of money for? Is it security? When you make it into this kind of love, there is not any fear in it. You become dangerous. There is no fear in it.

God's Love Is Perfected as We Love One Another

Maybe we need to go over there and look at it for a minute. First John 4:12 says:

No man hath seen God at any time.
If we love one another,
God dwelleth in us,
and his love is perfected in us.

I like that. God's love is perfected in me as we love one another.

Do you want the perfect love of God in you? Do you want Him to dwell in you like that? Then you are involved, whether I like it or not. His love will only perfect so far until I involve you. Otherwise, I do not need His power. What do I need it for if I do not care for you?

Verse 13 says:

Hereby know we that we dwell in him,
and he in us,
because he hath given us of his Spirit.
And we have seen and do testify
that the Father sent the Son
to be the Saviour of the world.
Whosoever shall confess that Jesus is the Son of God,
God dwelleth in him,
and he in God.
And we have known and believed the love that God hath to us.
God is love;
and he that dwelleth in love
dwelleth in God,
and God in him.

God is what? Love.

I am a person. God is love. He does not merely love. He is love. Love cannot act any other way. Anything God does in history or in time to come will be for your good.

God is love. He is made of it. He is the origin of all of it. The more you saturate in love, the more you will dwell in Him, because that is what He is.

"I want to draw close to God."

The minute you do, He will want you to meet somebody else's need. It is a vicious circle.

If you think, "I am not going out there with those old sinners. I am too holy," you will end up in a monastery with a little square window, burning a candle and peeking out at the dirty, sinful world.

"Do not touch me, for I have sanctified myself and am holier than you."

God cannot use that. He wants you to get strong enough. He needs you.

God is love, and he that dwells in love dwells in God, and God in him. That is heavy.

Perfect Love Removes Fear and Gives Boldness in Judgment

Verse 17 says:

Herein is our love made perfect,
that we may have boldness in the day of judgment:
because as he is,
so are we in this world.

Herein is our love made perfect. How is my love made perfect? Why is it made perfect? That we may have boldness in the day of judgment, because as He is, so are we in this world.

What is He? He is love.

As He is, so are we. We are what He is, and He is love.

He is also righteousness. He is sanctification. He is redemption. He is wisdom. He is healing. He is victory. He is faith. He is all in all. He is Jesus. But the bottom of all of it is love.

God is love, and as He is, so are we in this world.

How is my love made perfect, so perfect that on the day of judgment I can stand with boldness? What would perfect my love to that state?

He says:

There is no fear in love;
but perfect love casteth out fear:
because fear hath torment.
He that feareth
is not made perfect in love.
We love him,
because he first loved us.

The perfecting of love in you is getting rid of fear. The one who is made perfect in love has no fear, no torment, and that boldness will carry you clear through to the day of judgment, because as He is, you are in this world.

This reveals two things. First, His love is perfected in us as we love one another and serve. Second, the eradication of fear is the perfection of love.

Believe me, you will have to learn to get rid of fear if you are going to love your brother.

God is love. God is love.